

ployed and the Soviet Gosplans set the tone for India's attempts a couple of decades later. By the early '70s, these ideas had lost much of their legitimacy. It was recognised that the investments undertaken by the state had not effectively eliminated poverty and political agendas as well as economic policies began to directly address rural backwardness.

Mahalanobis's most remarkable and lasting contributions were the setting up of large-scale surveys, the application of statistical theory to a variety of Indian problems and the creation of institutions within which such work could be continued during and after his lifetime. After studying mathematics and physics at Cambridge, England, he returned to Calcutta in 1915 and began teaching physics at Presidency College. He was fascinated by statistical methods, began studying these intensively and started a small statistical laboratory in the college. This evolved into the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in 1932. He established the journal *Sankhya* in 1933 and as statistical advisor to the Cabinet, he founded the National Sample Survey (NSS) in 1950 and the Central Statistical Organisation in 1951.

Mahalanobis used statistical methods to better understand an enormous range of social and physical phenomena. In the early '20s, he used data from the Anglo-Indian community in Calcutta to arrive at measures of differences in the physical characteristics of communities. In the mid-'30s, he was asked by the Central Jute Committee to conduct a survey to estimate jute yield for the whole of Bengal. It was this large-scale survey that set the stage for the first round of NSS in 1950. These NSS rounds continue largely unchanged and are the primary source of data for studies on Indian living standards and poverty.

What makes this list of achievements remarkable? When the NSSO began, there were simply no large-scale surveys of its kind anywhere, let alone in the poorer parts of the world. More than four-fifths of the Indian



Q: What was the name of the famous paper on which the Mahalanobis model was based?

A: The Operational Research Approach to Planning in India

Q: When did he establish the ISI?

A: December 1932

Q: From which college did he complete his Tripos degree in Physics?

A: King's College, Cambridge

Q: How was he connected with Rabindranath Tagore?

A: He was the earliest biographer of his literary output

Q: What did he gift to the then prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru after his China visit?

A: A rare self-written monograph of his impressions of China

population lived in villages and yet less than a third of these were connected by paved roads. In this setting, the NSS attempted a low-cost survey to gather nationally representative data on the social conditions of households, many of whom could only be reached by enumerators passing through miles of forest. This could not have happened without the combination of technical expertise, energy, tenacity, and leadership that characterised Mahalanobis. India has now produced several famous statisticians, most of whom have been associated with the ISI and some have made truly fundamental contributions to the field of statistics. What distinguished Mahalanobis was the range of practical questions he was interested in and the seriousness with which he applied scientific methods to their exploration.

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